

Political Deepfakes Are as Credible as Other Fake Media and (Sometimes) Real Media

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Barari, Lucas & Munger (2025)
Journal of Politics, 23 October 2026

Deepfakes are feared as a threat to democracy

“…a corrosive impact on our democracy.”

Senators Rubio and Warner on deepfakes, 2019

2022	Deepfakes of Zelenskyy and Putin circulate during the Russia–Ukraine war
>12	US states regulate the production and spread of deepfake videos
Anyone	Open-source tools: hobbyists can make them, not only VFX experts

Is the fear backed by evidence? The paper tests it in two survey experiments.

Research questions: do deepfakes deceive more than other media?

RQ1

Are deepfake videos more credible than the same fake news as text or audio?

Preregistered expectation

Yes: video is uniquely deceptive

RQ2

Are deepfakes more credible to specific groups?

Preregistered expectation

Yes: older adults, partisans, sexists, low reflection, knowledge or digital literacy

RQ3

Are deepfakes as credible as authentic videos of politicians?

Preregistered expectation

Yes: nearly indistinguishable

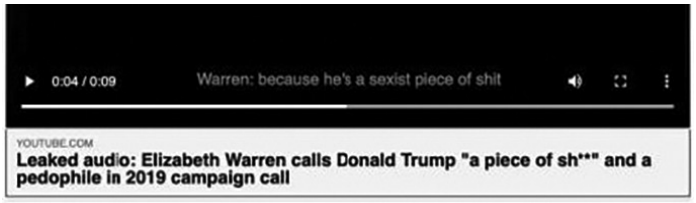
Spoiler: the first two expectations are rejected, the third gets a nuanced answer.

Design: one fake scandal in six conditions, then a detection task



Video: the deepfake

n = 872, face-swap, titled as leaked phone video



Audio

n = 954, actor's voice only, titled as leaked hot mic


Leak: Elizabeth Warren calls Donald Trump "a piece of s—" in 2019 campaign call

In call with a campaign contributor, Warren was recorded calling President Donald Trump "a piece of sh**" and a pedophile.

Text

n = 950, headline describing the leak

Source: Barari, Lucas & Munger (2025), Table 3

Sample: 5,724 US adults (Lucid)

Experiment 1

Fake Warren scandal in 6 conditions (video, audio, text, skit, attack ad, control) × deepfake warning

Outcome: "fake or doctored?" (1–5)

Experiment 2

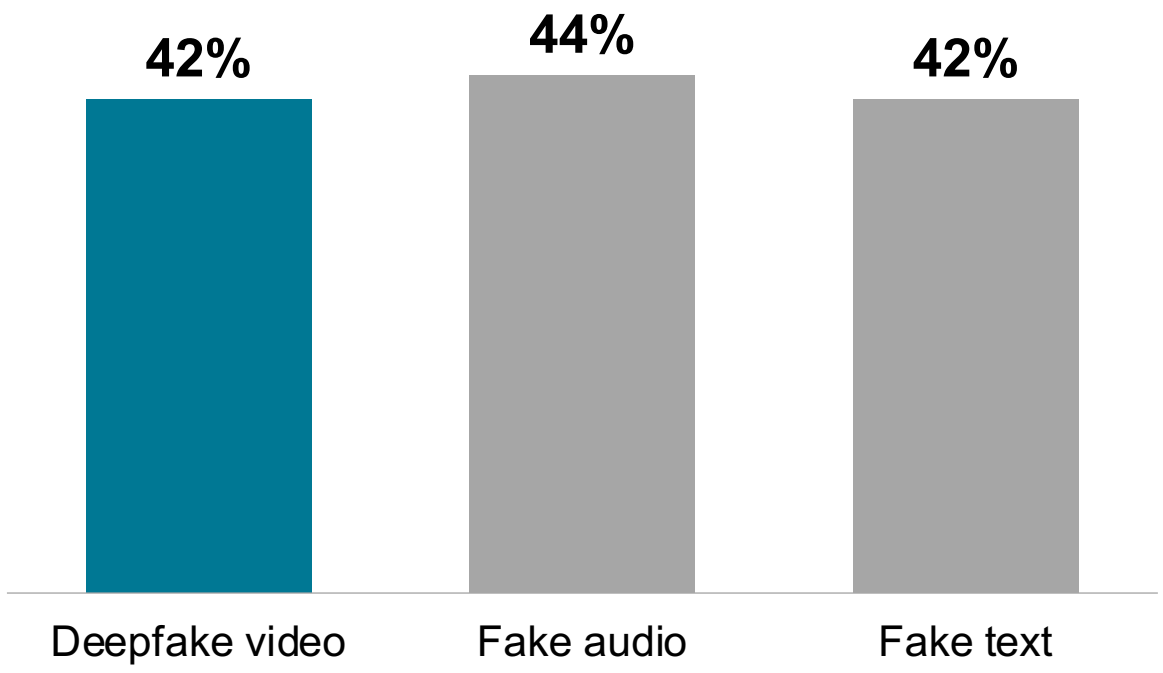
8 clips, 0 / 25 / 75 % deepfakes

Outcomes: accuracy, false negatives and positives

Link to class: stimuli from the same deep-learning family as CNNs and GANs

RQ1 and RQ2: deepfakes are no more credible than text or audio

Share rating the clip as credible (not fake or doctored)



Source: Barari, Lucas & Munger (2025), Fig. 2C; n ≈ 870–950 per condition

Credibility

Differences of up to ±0.5 SD are ruled out (equivalence test)

Affect

Video moves Warren's thermometer no more than text or audio, and at least as much as a real attack ad

Subgroups

No group (age, partisanship, sexism, reflection, knowledge) is especially fooled by video

RQ3, part 1: detecting deepfakes is barely better than chance

52–60 %

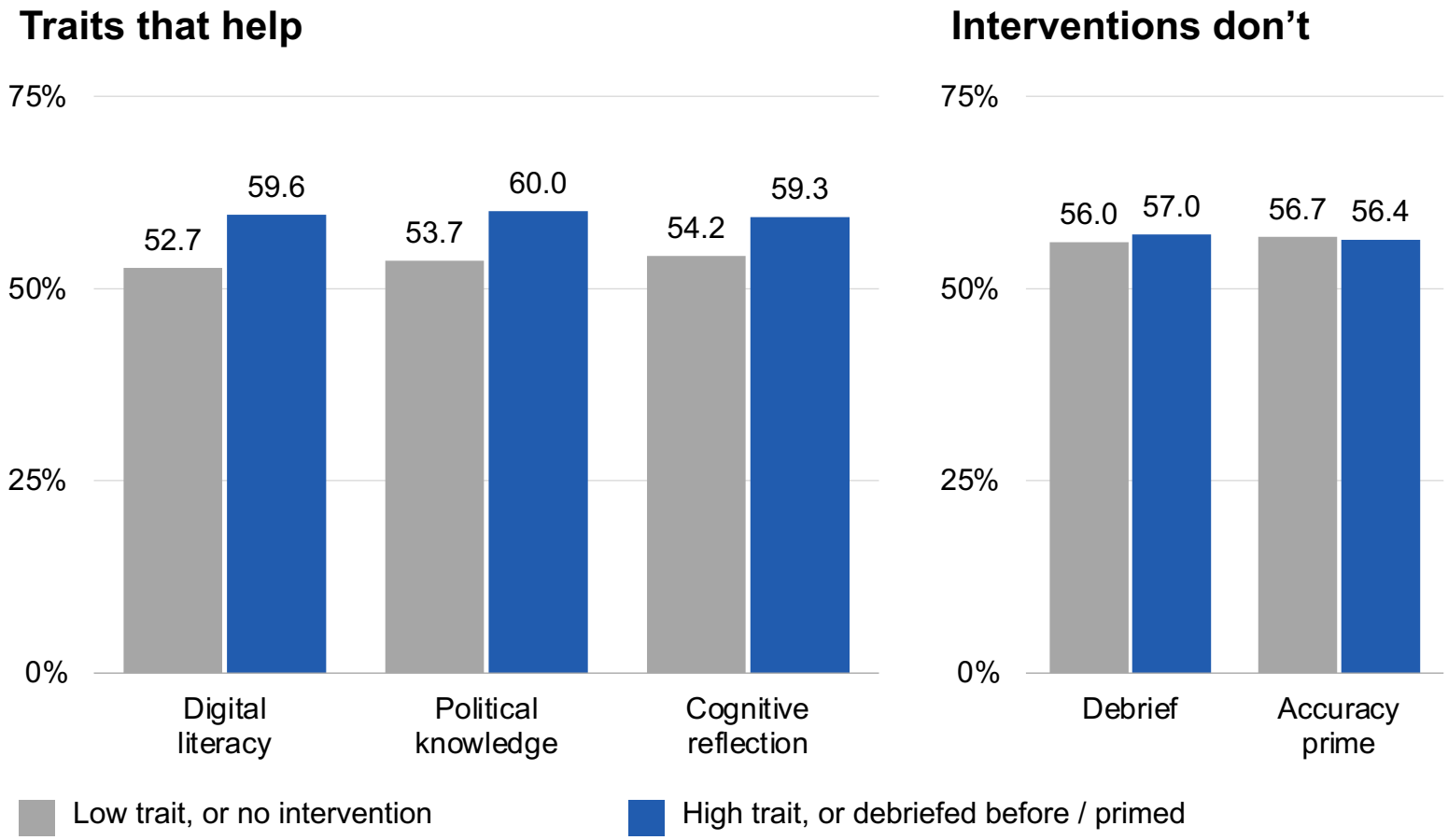
Accuracy across all groups (chance = 50 %)

33 %

of deepfakes judged authentic (false negatives)

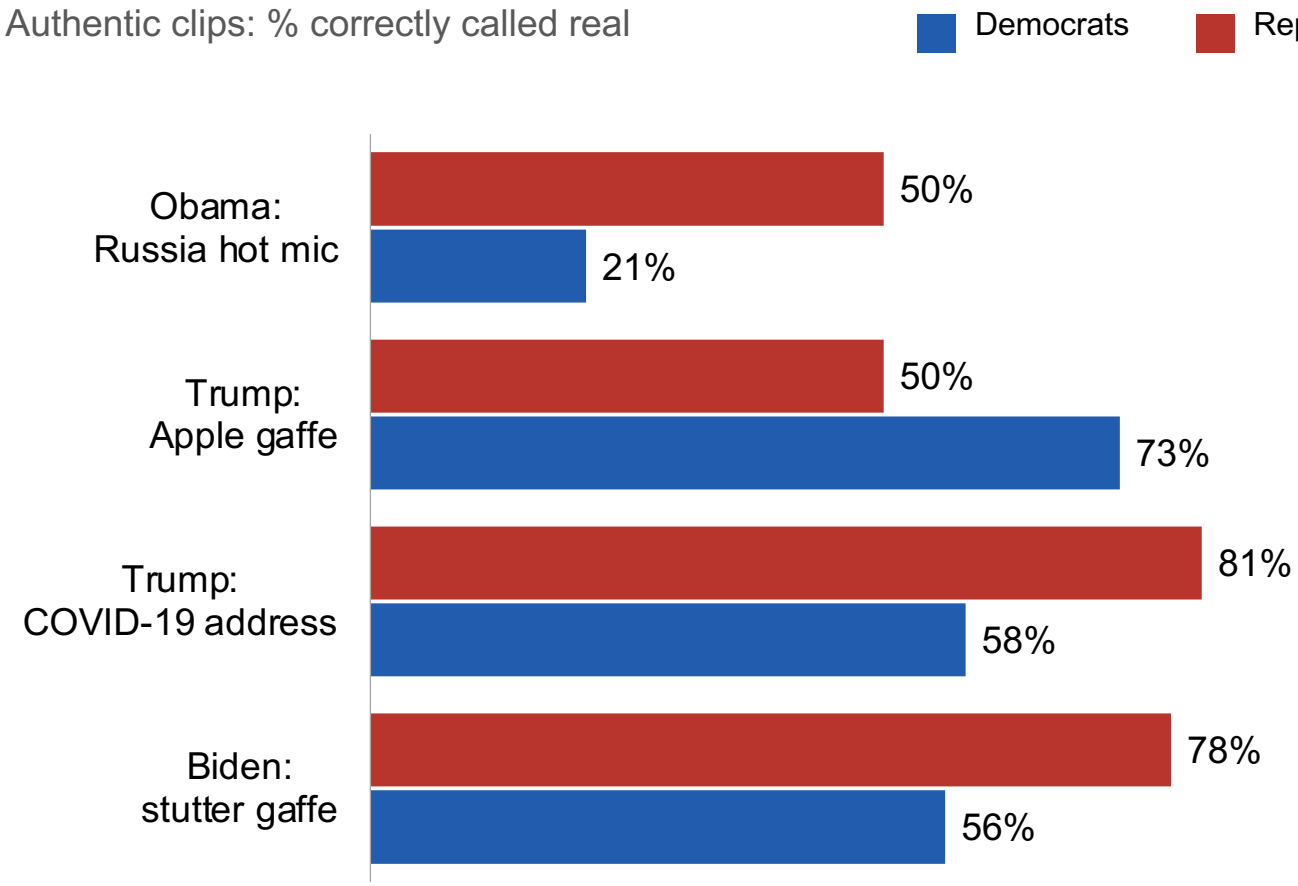
≈20 %

of real clips judged fake (false positives)



Source: Barari, Lucas & Munger (2025), Fig. 3 (detection accuracy, weighted)

RQ3, part 2: partisanship distorts judgements of real videos



≤ 2.3 pp

Democrat–Republican gap in correct detection, for all six deepfakes

up to 29 pp

gap for authentic clips: uncongenial clips are dismissed as fake

Source: Barari, Lucas & Munger (2025), Fig. 5; pp = percentage points

Is it convincing? Strengths and limits

What convinces us

- Clean randomised contrast: same script and actor, only the modality changes
- Reports equivalence tests, not just “not significant”
- Preregistered, N = 5'724, new stimuli, public replication data
- Experiment 2 adds many real-world clips

What worries us

- Mostly nulls: little learned about why, and ±0.5 SD is a generous bound
- Awareness: does a “deepfake study” make people suspicious? Everyone is asked “fake or doctored?”
- Reproducibility: assignment and scales (e.g. cognitive reflection) not in the main text, stimuli unreleased
- Narrow scope: one target (Warren), US 2020, one short exposure, dated technology
- Detection clips differ in more than authenticity

Implications and ethical concerns

Implications

Protect real media
Doubting authentic video is a cost, too

Warnings are a trade-off
Fewer fakes believed, but real videos doubted

Look at the harm to targets
Most deepfakes online are non-consensual porn of women

Invest in literacy
Digital literacy and knowledge improve discernment

Ethics

- Authors made deepfakes of a real politician. Safeguards: not a current candidate, active debriefs, videos not downloadable
- Our concern: dual use. Results from 2020-era technology may understate today's risk

Discussion

1 If deepfakes are not more convincing than text, should regulation treat them differently, or target the harm to the people depicted?

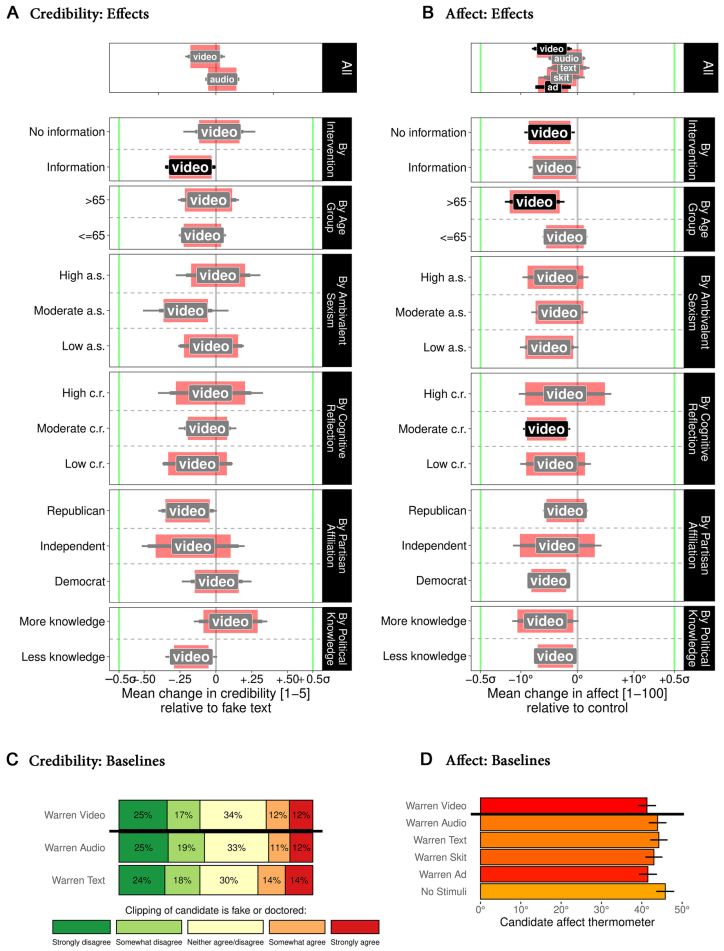
2 Warnings made people doubt real videos, too. What would a better intervention look like?

Backup: subgroups hypothesised to be susceptible

Subgroup	Mechanism of credibility
Older adults (65+)	Cannot evaluate accuracy of digital information
Partisans (out-partisan target)	Directional or accuracy-motivated reasoning about out-partisans
Sexists (female target)	Consistency with prior hostile or benevolent beliefs about women
Low cognitive reflection	Intuition over analytical thinking
Low political knowledge	Cannot judge plausibility or recognise real facial features
Low digital literacy	Cannot evaluate digital information; unaware of the technology
Low accuracy salience, uninformed about deepfakes	Intervenable: no attention to accuracy, no knowledge of deepfakes

Source: Barari, Lucas & Munger (2025), Table 1

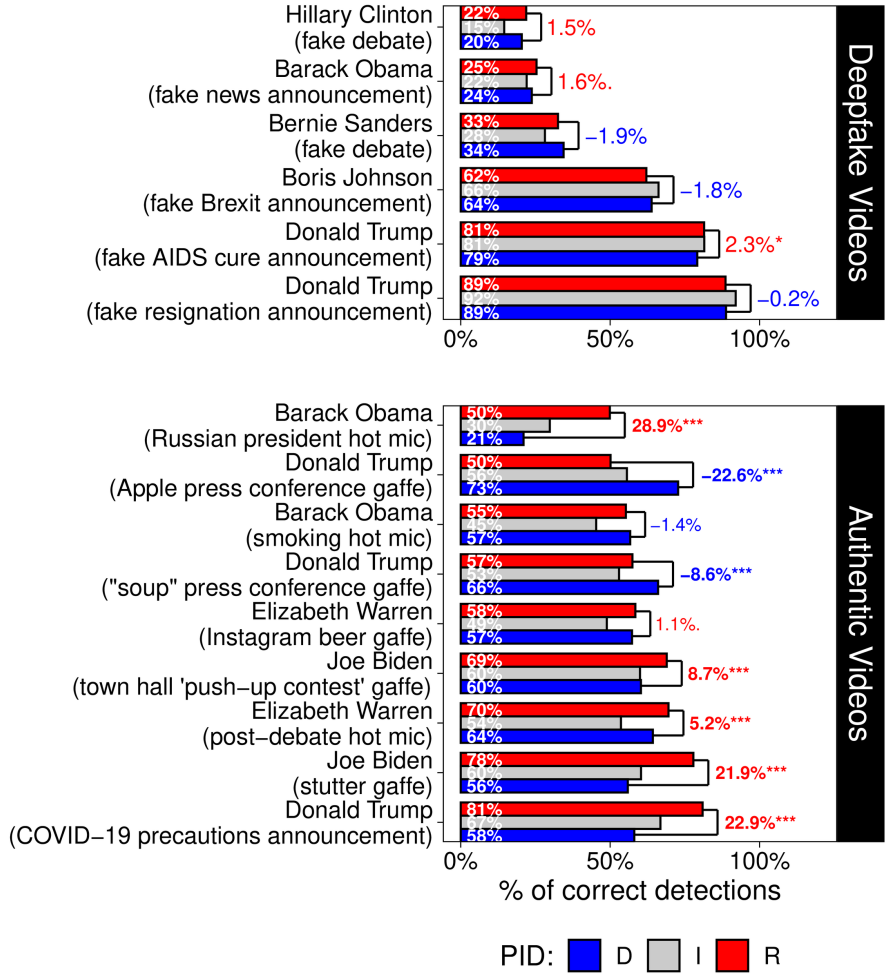
Backup: credibility and affect, by subgroup (Fig. 2)



- Panel A: credibility effect relative to fake text
- Panel B: affect towards Warren relative to control
- Red blocks: equivalence tests, effects are substantively null
- Thick lines: 95% CIs, thin lines: adjusted for multiple comparisons

Source: Barari, Lucas & Munger (2025), Fig. 2

Backup: detection by party and clip (Fig. 5)



- Share of correct detections per clip, by party ID
- Top: six deepfakes (gaps within about 2 pp)
- Bottom: nine authentic clips (gaps up to 29 pp)
- Stars: significance of the Democrat–Republican difference

Source: Barari, Lucas & Munger (2025), Fig. 5